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Boston police using Flock competitors

Deployment of license-plate-reading cameras sparks similar privacy concerns

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Among the law enforcement agencies in Massachusetts that have so far managed to dodge the backlash over the use of traffic surveillance cameras from Flock Safety is the Boston Police Department, which dropped the vendor last year

after a short trial. But this year, Boston instead started pilot programs for automatic license-plate-reading cameras with Flock's main competitors: Motorola Solutions in January, and Axon in June, according to city records obtained by the Globe. The records don't say how many cameras are in

the city or when the programs will end. Flock cameras in particular have triggered a raging controversy across the country, in part because officers don't need a warrant or subpoena to access the data. Also the long reach of Flock's shared network, with more than 100,000 such cameras around the United States, allows law enforcement to reconstruct a detailed itinerary of drivers. Disclosures that some police offi-

cers inappropriately used them to track ex-wives or former partners prompted a slew of towns to cut ties with Flock and raised questions about whether departments have enough oversight over the technology. Axon and Motorola carry seemingly identical features to Flock — and for critics, identical concerns. And in Boston, disclosure of the pilot programs triggered a separate

SURVEILLANCE, Page A7

A lottery triumph, with big recoil

Critics blast online rollout for use of cartoon images, say games attract children

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

Massachusetts' online lottery has charged out of the gate, attracting 187,000 registered users and \$119 million in wagers in just a month. More than \$1.6 million was wagered on opening day alone, leading state lottery officials to tout it as the most successful online lottery launch in US history. But that early triumph has come with a healthy dose of controversy. Public health advocates and several state lawmakers are blasting the Massachusetts State Lottery Commission over the mobile app's arcade style, child-friendly graphics, and porous age-verification safeguards. They warn that the platform will accelerate a troubling rise in underage gambling — a surge fueled in recent years by the omnipresence of mobile sports betting apps such as DraftKings and FanDuel. At least three of the iLottery's 20-plus new games — “The Claw,” “Prize Chickens,” and “The Lamp” — feature cartoon animals and prizes

SHARE OF HIGH SCHOOL STUDENTS WHO REPORTED PLAYING THE LOTTERY

2021 28% **↑** **2025 37%**

straight out of a children's arcade. “The Claw” mirrors the classic game found in many grocery stores where players maneuver a crane to snag toys. “Prize Chickens” showcases animated birds alongside flying eggs and feathers, while “The Lamp” incorporates genie imagery reminiscent of Disney's animated film “Aladdin.” Public health advocates and antigambling activists have likened the cartoonish imagery to “Joe Camel” — the infamous mascot used by R.J. Reynolds Co. to market Camel cigarettes that drew fury in the 1980s and '90s for targeting youths and helping to hook a new generation of smokers. For now, anyone can play the new arcade-style “eInstant” games on the Mass Lottery's app for free without verifying their age. That loophole allows children to play without proving they are 21, the legal gambling age for online users in Massachusetts

LOTTERY, Page A10

Possible repeal may not deter cannabis users

Ballot vote an annoyance, not barrier, consumers say

By Dana Gerber
GLOBE STAFF

Stuart Scipione started smoking weed before it was legal, and, if need be, he will smoke if it no longer is. That being said, it's not a world he's anxious to return to. The 43-year-old recalls “a lot of white-knuckle purchases” back when he started lighting up as a twenty-something in Sharon. Those were the days of clandestine meetups behind a 7-11 or in a Jordan's Furniture parking lot, baggies full of seeds and stems, and evading run-ins with cops — a far cry from the simple dispensary transactions he has since grown used to. “It was a nightmare,” the Foxborough resident said. “I don't honestly miss any part of what it was like back in the day.” A ballot question this November, however, could bring back those hush-hush handoffs. If it passes, Question 8 would make Massachusetts the first state to dismantle its recreational weed market. Not only could consumers no longer buy it, they would not be allowed to grow it at home, either, and the legal limits on possession would be scaled back. The prospect has Scipione considering how he might navigate a rollback on the down-low — without giving up his highs. “I think I'd probably be hanging out behind a 7-11 somewhere, hoping I'd find someone that looks shady enough to sell me a bag,” he said. It's a potential dilemma for many of the state's regular dispensary customers, who have had

CANNABIS, Page A7

In hidden underground realm, history and mysteries lurk



PHOTOS BY CARLOS MUÑOZ/GLOBE STAFF

Sandor Bodo led a group on a tour of Providence's East Side railroad tunnel, which is packed with graffiti (below).

Once, this R.I. tunnel rumbled with trains. Today, it's an eerie lair of artists.



By Edward Fitzpatrick
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE

Most Rhode Islanders have seen the East Side Transit Tunnel, which buses use to climb College Hill from downtown Providence. But there's another tunnel that's become part of local lore: an abandoned railroad tunnel that runs for a dark, dank mile beneath the East Side of Providence. That tunnel, which hasn't seen a train in at least 45 years, was the scene of a 1993 disturbance involving college students carrying torches, police firing pepper spray, and authorities making claims about Satanic rituals. Now the tunnel has been thrust back into the spotlight as the city leads an effort to save the Crook Point Bascule Bridge, a rusted, state-

TUNNEL, Page A10

A FINAL WAVE GOODBYE



DANIEL SARCH FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Former Celtic Jaylen Brown addressed the crowd at his 741 Frequency Fest Sunday on Boston Common. The event featured music, games, food trucks, and lots of mutual love. **B1.**

In the first military strike in a month, US forces attacked Iranian rocket launchers at the Strait of Hormuz, and Iran sent missiles toward Jordan in retaliation. **A6.**

The National Park Service said a deadly flash flood in Grand Canyon has left up to 15 hikers missing. **A2.**

For state Senate candidates Daniel Lander and Latoya Gayle, a hearty endorsement from Boston Mayor Michelle Wu brings opportunity and a potential rise in funds, along with questions on their independence. **B1.**

The Patriots finalized their roster, cutting 37 players in the past two days. **C1.**

Ruoning Yin held on to take golf's FM Championship in Norton. **C1.**

The Sox lost their third game in four against the Yankees, falling 16-1 and farther behind in wild-card race. **C1.**



Sweet 'n' sour

Monday: Sunny but cooler. High 73-78, low 64-69.

Tuesday: Cloudy with showers. High 70-75, low 62-67.

Sunrise: 6:08. Sunset: 7:20.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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